

User account types

Microsoft seems to have gone crazy over the number '2'. Windows 8 can be used with two types of accounts, and no, we won't bore you with details about differences between administrator and normal accounts. What we will talk about though are 'Local accounts' and 'Microsoft accounts' – concepts new to Windows 8. A Microsoft account is an account whose credentials (email and password) you'd use to sign in to Microsoft services such as Hotmail, Live and Bing. A local account, on the other hand, is one which you use to sign in only to your PC.

When we use a Microsoft account to sign in to Windows 8, the OS actually takes care of syncing the settings, files and favorites from Microsoft servers (basically, the cloud). When using a Microsoft account to sign in to Windows 8, it's not mandatory to be connected to the internet at all times. Actually, it's not mandatory at all, except when you first select the type of account you want to use for signing in. This is because a 'Microsoft account' from a Windows 8 perspective is simply a local account to which credentials of a Microsoft account have been synced and stored locally. If you don't want to sync and store everything online, you can 'Switch to a local account'. The option is available in the Users section of PC Settings.

Assuming you're already using a 'Microsoft account' to log in to your machine, you can opt to switch to a local account by clicking that button. When you do this, you'll be asked to enter your current password. The next screen will ask you to enter a username, password (twice) and password hint. While you may expect Windows 8 to annihilate all your files and preferences and get you a new account, nothing could be further from the truth. The only thing it does is change your password stored on disk, add a password hint and change your username (if you enter a different username).

If you're not using a Microsoft account, (it doesn't matter if you switched to a local account or didn't opt for one while installing Windows 8) you'll get an option to switch to a Microsoft account in PC Settings. You'll be asked to enter your password and then the email address and password of the account you want to connect to. Once done, your apps, passwords, files, calendar, mail etc. will be synced.

File History

File History is one of the long awaited features of Windows 8. Typically, file backups have to be taken manually: you either write the data to a CD/DVD or copy it to a USB drive or external hard disk. The File History feature